

THE ART OF THE WET FLY

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic · Student Handout · Condensed from the Full Program

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2.5 hrs 8:00 AM–10:30 AM	~1.75 hrs ON-WATER TIME	5 SESSIONS	3 METHODS INTRODUCED
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Traditional Swing · Dead Drift Wet · Pattern Logic

Resources: [Leader Construction](#) · [Fly Casting Terms & Definitions](#) · [Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions](#)

QUICK REFERENCE — FOUR METHODS AT A GLANCE

METHOD	DESCRIPTION
Traditional Swing	Quarter-downstream cast on floating line, upstream mend, low rod track, let fly hang — step-and-swing grid covers all water.
Dead Drift Wet	Upstream 45° cast, high rod tracks fly downstream at current speed with zero tension. Most demanding line control in fly fishing.
Induced Method	Upstream, across, and downstream presentations with a cast of flies. Leisenring Lift at target lie triggers instinctive take.
Contact / Evolutionary	Tight-line swing with gentle fly animation. Straight-down feed for unreachable lies.

PATTERNS & CAST OF FLIES LOGIC

CATEGORY	PATTERNS & LOGIC
Winged Wets (Point Fly)	Leadwing Coachman, Hare’s Ear wet, March Brown wet, Royal Coachman wet — weight and profile
Soft Hackles (Dropper)	Partridge & Orange, Starling & Herl, Pheasant Tail soft hackle — pulsing tier, mobile in current
SA Originals	Tellico, Yallerhammer, Jim Charley, Thunderhead, Crackleback — attractor logic, regional heritage
Cast of Flies Logic	Point: heaviest/most suggestive · Middle dropper: lighter attractor · Top dropper: smallest/lightest

STRIKE DETECTION BY METHOD

METHOD	DETECTION
Traditional Swing	Jolting take on tight line — fish often hook themselves; shock loop absorbs explosive takes
Dead Drift Wet	Subtle pull or tick — raise rod immediately; no tension in system until you create it
Leisenring Lift	Confident take as fly rises — fish commits, no refusal behavior; lift firmly, don't strike hard

ROD & GEAR SELECTION

TOPIC	DETAIL
Rod Action	Mid-flex or soft-tip 9.5–11 ft in 3–4 wt. Soft tip cushions takes, loads roll cast.
Floating Line	Ideal for classic swing in 1–3 ft water. Best control, easiest mending, most visibility.
Leader Length	12–16 ft total on a 5X base. Longer leaders keep fly line off the water in the induced method.
Dropper Spacing	20–30" between droppers, open-loop uni-knot on each fly for maximum pulsing movement.

2.5-Hour Foundations Clinic

8:00 – 8:15 am Philosophy, the big advantage & gear check

PHILOSOPHY + GEAR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the four-method framework and why water coverage is the wet fly's primary advantage
- Assemble a two-fly leader before going to the water

KEY CONCEPTS

Mid-flex soft-tip 10 ft 3–4 wt: cushions takes, loads roll cast · Floating line for classic swing · Leader: 12–14 ft, 5X, two-fly rig with dropper 24" up from point

ACTIVITIES

- Quick two-fly rig assembly check
- Roll cast turnover test on flat water before going to the river

Checkpoint: Each student's two-fly leader turns over cleanly on a roll cast before advancing to the river.

8:15 – 8:25 am · Walk to water

8:25 – 9:25 am Traditional swing — down-and-across on the step grid**TRADITIONAL****LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

- Execute the quarter-downstream cast and control swing speed with mending
- Step-and-swing grid from top to bottom of a run without missing lanes
- Develop hang patience — 5-count before recasting

KEY CONCEPTS

Quarter-downstream cast: 45° to current · Upstream mend immediately: lets fly sink before tensioning · Belly management: mend to slow, lead rod to speed · The hang: fly rises at end of swing — most strikes happen here · Shock loop: 8–12" of line between fingers absorbs hard takes

ACTIVITIES

- Swing drill: quarter cast, upstream mend, low rod track, 5-count hang
- Step-and-swing grid: cover a stretch of riffle run top to bottom

Checkpoint: Each student grids a stretch of riffle run systematically. Instructor checks swing speed and hang patience.

9:25 – 9:45 am Patterns & cast of flies logic for today's water**PATTERNS****LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

- Apply attractor-first logic for Southern Appalachian water
- Assemble a cast of flies with correct point/dropper reasoning

KEY CONCEPTS

Attractors first: Tellico, Yallerhammer, soft hackle Coachman · Point: heaviest and most suggestive; dropper: lighter, more mobile

ACTIVITIES

- Fly board sort: attractor vs. imitative split, justify the placement
- Current conditions check: any hatch evidence? Adjust dropper if warranted

Checkpoint: Each student can name the point and dropper fly for today's water and explain why.

9:45 – 10:20 am Dead drift wet fly — introduction**DEAD DRIFT****LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

- Understand why dead drift demands total line control discipline
- Execute an upstream cast and achieve a tension-free drift on moderate current

KEY CONCEPTS

Dead drift: upstream 45° cast, high rod tracks fly at current speed, zero tension · Strike detection: subtle feel or leader twitch — raise rod immediately · Transition: when line tightens, dead drift becomes the swing — use it, don't fight it

ACTIVITIES

- Upstream dead drift drill on flat to moderate water, partner watches leader for drag
- One attempt at the transition from drift into the swing

Checkpoint: Each student achieves a short tension-free drift and recognizes the transition into the swing.

10:20 – 10:30 am Final debrief & written feedback

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one priority to build on

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment returned to each student
- One strength and one priority — verbal

Checkpoint: Each student leaves with one written strength and one named priority for the next time on the water.